and, above all, could quote the latest archaeological research on the site. How do you know so much, I asked? It turned out the guides are licensed (and presumably paid) by the government. To keep their licences, they attend short courses on the latest research on the artefacts and history of the burial grounds. No Indian guide I had ever encountered could match this smiling, proud, erudite man. The visit was a telling soft power moment. Exposed to ancient and modern Xi'an, I was left simultaneously admiring and deflated – admiring of Chinese infrastructure and attention to detail and deflated at how India, with its rich legacies, does such an underwhelming job of marketing and curating them.

As I walked around Xi'an, I remembered what a Chinese colleague often said to me. He had visited India several times, been to many of the usual tourist spots, in and around Delhi, and loved Indian food and company. When we travelled in China and India together as part of our research, he would frequently shake his head: 'India has much more to showcase than China. So many things in China were destroyed by war and modernization. You have kept your monuments, but Indian tourist facilities are so horrible!' I thought back, too, to a shocking fact that a JNU graduate student working on tourism policy had shared during the defence of his thesis proposal in the late 1990s: that Bangkok had more hotel rooms than all of India combined. Years later, when tourism in India was doing better, it turned out a lot more hotel rooms were available. The Indian hotel industry had now caught up with Shanghai!

On my final day in Xi'an, I was to get another surprise. In the middle of the city, somewhere near the famous Bell Tower of the fourteenth century, was a row of little shops, rather like Janpath in Delhi. In a consumerist fever, wanting to memorialize my trip to Xi'an, I decided to buy some souvenirs. A smiling old lady waved me into her stall. Armed with a basket, I went round and loaded up. As she totted up the bill, I flourished my yuan, Singapore dollars, and US bills. 'No, no, no money!' I put away the currency and brought out my plastic. 'No, no, no card, no card.' At this point, I was nonplussed. I was from rich, advanced Singapore: what was going on? In effect, here was high-tech at ground zero, and I was 'out of it'.